express using policies alone. The team designing the customer platform eventually concluded that ABAC's ability to evaluate static conditions at runtime wasn't well-suited for expressing dynamic, graph-based relationships. That's when they started exploring ReBAC for relationship-aware authorization.

Finally, ABAC's reliance on centrally managed policies means that access control can be highly centralized. Although attributes originated from distributed sources, only a small group of developers or policy administrators might be employed to write or modify policies. This bottleneck reduces agility and causes some teams to wait before implementing new access rules. While ABAC provides precise control, it lacks the delegation and self-service features that modern collaboration platforms increasingly need. For ACME, ABAC remained crucial in environments with stable requirements and strict compliance, but it wasn't a universal solution.

Many of ABAC's limitations stem not from the model itself but from its implementation and governance. Implementing clear policies, maintaining consistent attribute naming, enforcing strong version control, and using testing and simulation tools can significantly reduce complexity. Organizational standards and governance practices are essential for managing policy sprawl, avoiding confusion, and keeping access decisions transparent and auditable over time. We'll revisit these topics in detail in chapter 19, which covers policy governance and the operational practices needed to make models like ABAC sustainable at scale.

6.3 A hybrid approach: Policy-based access control

As ACME Corp's authorization needs grew more complex, it became clear that no single model—whether based on roles, relationships, or attributes—could address all use cases. Engineers needed to enforce contextual access to production systems. Support teams shared documents based on customer relationships. Finance required auditable, policy-driven controls to ensure regulatory compliance. Each team had unique requirements, and each relied on a different model.